workers. These two categories of workers—those who are underemployed and the potential labour force—when added to the unemployed offer the measure of total underutilized labour.

The universe of workers comprises all economic spheres of production and all workers, whether in paid employment or self-employment.

ILO counted the global working age population at 5.7 billion in 2019; 3.5 billion or 61 per cent of this population was in the labour force and 2.3 billion, or 39 per cent, were not. Of the 3.5 billion workers in the labour force, 3.3 billion were employed (57 per cent of the working age population) and 188 million were unemployed (4 per cent). The unemployment rate (unemployed/workforce) was 5.4 per cent. Total labour underutilized was 473 million, about 14 per cent.

The employment to population ratio is gradually reducing worldwide for the past twenty-five years. It reduced 0.8 per cent during 1994–99, and 1 per cent during 1999–2004, 2004–09 and 2009–14. The reduction rate declined to 0.6 per cent in 2014–19. Even before COVID-19, the ILO expected the employment rate to reduce by 1.1 per cent in 2019–2024. The proportion of population to total working age population has declined by about 4.5 per cent in the past twenty-five years.

India Measures Labour Employment and Unemployment Quite Poorly

The country's official data collection on labour and employment status is abysmal. India used to conduct large sample-sized, five-year employment and unemployment surveys as part of the National Sample Survey (NSS) rounds. This quinquennial employment survey started in the twenty-seventh NSS round (1972–73) and the ninth survey was conducted in 2011–2012. That survey has been discontinued; no such survey took place in 2016–17.

These five-year surveys were replaced by an Annual Employment-Unemployment Survey. The first such survey was conducted in 2010 and